of these audio versions are listened to first. Once we have heard Feynman's forceful, enthralling, and witty commentary, in the tones of this streetwise New Yorker, we do not forget how he sounds, and it gives us an image to latch on to when we read his words. But whether we actually read the chapters or not, we can share something of the evident thrill that he himself feels as he explores—and continually re-explores—the extraordinary laws that govern the workings of our universe.

The present series of six lectures was carefully chosen to be of a level a little above the six that formed the earlier set of Feynman lectures entitled *Six Easy Pieces* (published by Addison Wesley Longman in 1995). Moreover, they go well together and constitute a superb and compelling account of one of the most important general areas of modern theoretical physics.

This area is *relativity*, which first burst forth into human awareness in the early years of this century. The name of Einstein figures preeminently in the public conception of this field. It was, indeed, Albert Einstein who, in 1905, first clearly enunciated the profound principles which underlie this new realm of physical endeavor. But there were others before him, most notably Hendrik Antoon Lorentz and Henri Poincaré, who had already appreciated most of the basics of the (then) new physics. Moreover, the great scientists Galileo Galilei and Isaac Newton, centuries before Einstein, had already pointed out that in the dynamical theories that they themselves were developing, the physics as perceived by an observer in uniform motion would be identical with that perceived by an observer at rest. The key problem with this had arisen only later, with James Clerk Maxwell's discovery, as published in 1865, of the equations that govern the electric and magnetic fields, and which also control the propagation of light. The implication seemed to be that the relativity principle of Galileo and Newton could no longer hold true; for the speed of light must, by Maxwell's equations, have a definite speed of propagation. Accordingly, an observer at rest is distinguished from those in motion by the fact that only to an observer at rest does the light speed appear to be the